

The PA Recruitment Market: 2025 in Review & Outlook to 2027

Salary trends · Hiring conditions · Economic context · Strategic outlook

With over 35 years placing outstanding Assistants across London and beyond, we are pleased to share our perspective on where the PA and business support market stands today and where it is heading. The past twelve months have been characterised by measured caution rather than contraction and we believe the foundations for a steadier, more confident market are firmly in place.

£45,500

Average London PA salary 2025 (up from ~£42k in 2023)

58%

of UK employers said the NI rise directly affected their hiring plans

Q1 2026

First improvement in Net Employment Outlook since mid-2025

1 Market Conditions: 2025 in Context

The UK recruitment market in 2025 was undeniably quieter than in the post-pandemic boom years but it would be wrong to characterise it as a recessionary environment. Rather, it reflected a recalibration - businesses becoming more thoughtful in when and how they hire, with a sharper focus on the quality and longevity of each appointment. For specialist PA recruitment in London, this dynamic is welcome - it favours depth of expertise over speed, which is precisely where a long-established agency like Anderson Hoare adds the greatest value.

According to recruitment data we've compiled, permanent placements remained in decline for much of 2025, although the rate of reduction slowed materially towards the end of the year. Temporary and contract PA appointments held up considerably better, with many clients opting for experienced contract support while long-term hiring decisions were deferred. Candidate supply increased, giving clients greater choice - though experienced, senior PAs with a strong track record remained genuinely competitive to secure but this has generally been the case since the pandemic ended.

2 The Employer National Insurance Increase

The single most significant external factor affecting hiring decisions in 2025 was the April introduction of higher employer National Insurance contributions. From 6 April 2025, the employer NIC rate rose from 13.8% to 15% and the threshold at which contributions begin was reduced from £9,100 to £5,000 per employee. For a PA earning £45,000, this translated into an additional annual cost of approximately £930 per hire - a meaningful sum, particularly for our smaller business clients and private households.

A British Chamber of Commerce survey found that 82% of UK companies were reviewing their operations in response and 58% expected a direct impact on recruitment. The practical effects we observed were broadly consistent with those predictions, some clients delayed or restructured hiring

plans, others explored part-time or hybrid arrangements and a higher number sought contract cover rather than permanent hires. However, the London PA market did not stall. Demand for high-calibre, experienced PAs remained consistent, particularly at the senior end of the market, where the value a skilled PA generates far outweighs the additional cost.

"The demand for high-quality PA support is structural, not cyclical. Cost pressures may slow the decision-making process but they have not diminished the fundamental need for expert personal support at senior level."

- Anderson Hoare, Spring 2026

3 PA Salary Trends: 2023–2026

Salaries in the London PA market have continued their upward trajectory, although the pace of growth has moderated as overall wage inflation eases. The market for experienced PAs, particularly those supporting C-suite principals or operating in professional services environments, remains genuinely competitive.

Level / Role	2023	2024	2025 London	2026 Projected
Junior / Senior Receptionist	£25-£36k	£27-38k	£28-43k	£30-45k
Graduate / Junior PA	£25-30k	£27-32k	£28-34k	£30-35k
Experienced PA (3–5 yrs)	£32-40k	£34-42k	£35-45k	£38-55k
Senior / C-Suite PA	£45-55k	£48-58k	£50-65k	£52-85k
Private / HNWI PA	£50-70k	£55-75k	£60-80k+	£65-100k+

4 What Candidates Expect in 2025–26

Despite increased candidate availability, the best PAs remain highly selective. Hybrid flexibility has become a baseline expectation for many candidates, although this option is now at the lowest level of 1 day work from home. This has important implications for clients, a competitive salary alone is not necessarily the main criteria to attract or retain top talent, lifestyle also plays an important part.

Candidates are also placing increasing emphasis on the culture of the company they will be working for, alongside opportunities for genuine responsibility and the stability of the organisation. The mutual trust that comes with the longevity of the principal/assistant relationship remains important in all PA positions.

5 Outlook: 2026–2027

The early signals for 2026 are encouraging. The Purchasing Managers' Index for UK services rose to 54 in January 2026, a five-month high and the Net Employment Outlook registered its first positive move since mid 2025 in Q1 2026. Temporary billings returned to growth for the first time in three months, historically an early indicator of a broader market recovery. The rate of decline in permanent placements has slowed to its lowest level in 18 months.

Unemployment in the UK is expected to peak around 5.3% before declining gradually in 2027. Business confidence is rebuilding; Lloyds' Business Barometer held steady at 44% in early 2026, comfortably above

its long-term average of 30%. For the London PA market specifically, where demand is driven by the concentration of senior executives, financial institutions, law firms, and UHNW individuals, these broader trends are a positive backdrop.

Anderson Hoare Outlook: Key Themes for 2026–2027

- A gradual, sustained recovery in permanent hiring is expected through 2026 as employer confidence rebuilds and cost pressures stabilise
- Demand for experienced, senior PAs will outpace supply - clients who move decisively will secure the best candidates
- Contract and temporary PA positions will increase, many clients may convert successful temporary placements to permanent roles
- The private household and HNWI sector continues to be resilient
- Candidate expectations around flexibility and role quality are here to stay - clear, well-structured briefs and attractive working conditions will be essential
- AI tools are evolving the administrative landscape but are elevating, not replacing the PA role; demand is shifting towards PAs who combine traditional skills with digital confidence and strategic thinking

6 A Note from Anderson Hoare

Having worked in this market for over 35 years, we have seen economic cycles come and go. What we observe today is a market that is pausing to catch its breath, not retreating. The fundamentals underpinning demand for exceptional PA talent in London are as strong as ever - a concentration of world-leading businesses, an active private client community and a culture that values expert, trusted personal support at the highest levels.

We remain committed to providing our clients with the same rigorous, personal approach to PA recruitment that has defined Anderson Hoare since 1992. In a quieter market, the quality of the match matters more than ever and that is where we have always excelled.

We look forward to continuing to support you through 2026 and beyond. Please do not hesitate to get in touch to discuss your requirements or to talk through the recruitment landscape generally.